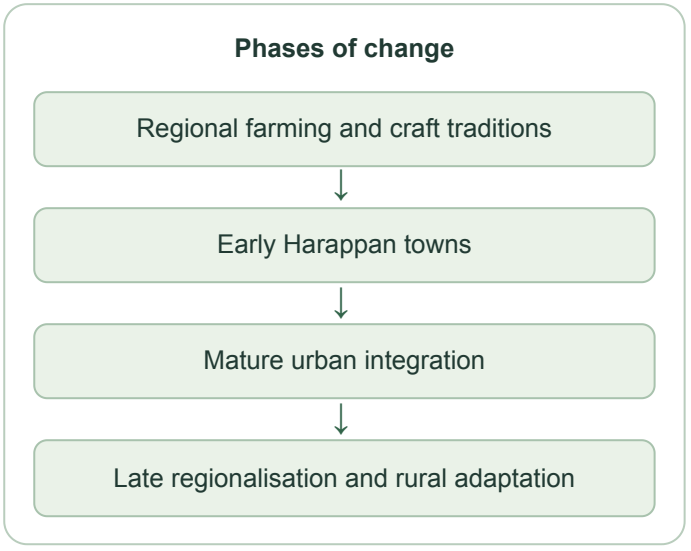
Harappan Civilisation / Bronze Age

1. Period, spread and origins

- **South Asia's first urban civilisation**, contemporary with Bronze Age Mesopotamia and Egypt; named after **Harappa**, the first major site excavated. **Protohistoric** because the script remains undeciphered. Its area was vastly greater than the book's erroneous “37 acres”.
- Developed through regional farming/craft traditions; overseas contacts do not prove that Mesopotamians created it. “Older than Chalcolithic cultures” is too broad: copper–stone cultures can precede, overlap or follow Harappan phases.

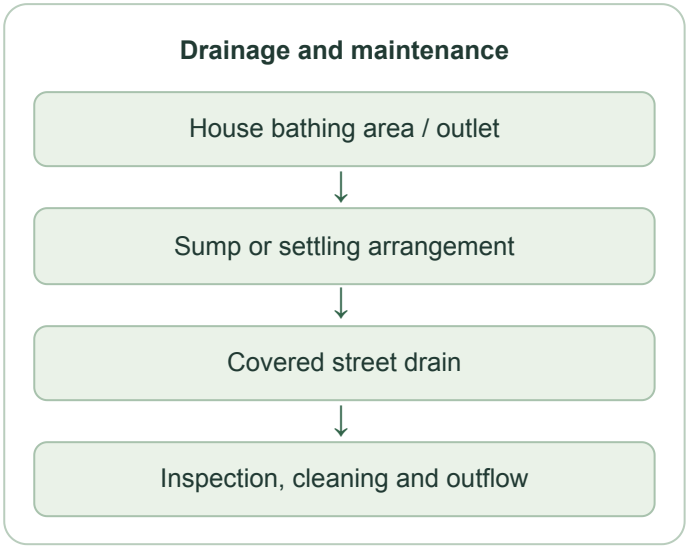
Phase	Approximate dates	Main change
Early / Regionalisation	c.3300/3200–2600 BCE	Larger villages, fortification, crafts, wheeled transport and trade; growth towards towns
Mature / Integration	**c.2600–1900 BCE**	Large cities, shared seals/script, standard weights and brick proportions; local diversity persists
Late / Localisation	**c.1900–1300 BCE**	Regionalisation and smaller/rural settlements; altered crafts, agriculture and exchange—not disappearance of all people



- **Core geography**: Indus plains and Ghaggar–Hakra belt; Punjab, Sindh, Balochistan, Rajasthan, Haryana, Gujarat and adjoining areas. Northwestern outpost: **Shortughai, Afghanistan**.
- Conventional textbook extent: **Manda (Jammu)—north; Alamgirpur (UP)—east; Sutkagendor (Balochistan)—west; Daimabad (Maharashtra)—south**. The outermost sites do not all represent the same phase or equally large cities.
- Early sites: **Amri, Kot Diji, Harappa, Kalibangan, Banawali, Bhirrana, Padri, Dholavira, Balakot, Gumla**. Many sites have more than one phase; absence in today's active floodplain can reflect alluvial burial/erosion, not proof of no settlement.

2. Town planning and water

- Many cities have a **raised citadel** and a **lower town**; arrangements vary. **Dholavira has multiple fortified divisions**; Chanhudaro is conventionally recalled for **no separate citadel**. A citadel does not by itself identify a king's residence.
- **Grid-like streets crossing at right angles**, blocks and lanes; major roads could approach 10 m, but widths vary. No secure universal evidence supports a system of regular street lamp-posts.
- Mudbrick and baked brick, stone prominently at Dholavira. Common mature brick ratio **thickness:width:length = 1:2:4**; examples **7×14×28 cm** and larger **10×20×40 cm**, not identical sizes everywhere.
- **Courtyard houses**, varied room counts, staircases indicating upper floors, bathing floors and wells in some homes. Entrances often open onto side lanes; don't turn this into an absolute rule for every house/city.
- **Covered street drains**, house outlets, soakage jars/sumps and removable covers show planned wastewater handling and maintenance. Not every house or settlement had an identical underground sewer network.
- **Dholavira**: channels, dams and reservoirs capture seasonal runoff; dry-region water management. **Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath**: approximately **11.9×7 m**, **2.4 m deep**, steps, waterproofed brickwork/bitumen, nearby water source and outlet; ritual bathing is a strong interpretation, not a deciphered written explanation.



Mains link: integrated land use, building standards, water conservation and sanitation are useful lessons today; direct, uninterrupted institutional transmission to modern municipalities is not established.

3. Society, authority and everyday life

- Occupational diversity: cultivators, herders, traders, potters, metalworkers, bead/shell workers and others. Different houses, ornaments and access to resources indicate social differentiation; **"mostly middle class", fixed three classes and slave barracks are unproven reconstructions**.
- Shared standards, large platforms, fortifications and coordinated construction imply organisation. **One empire, several rulers, merchant elites or other authority arrangements remain debated**; no deciphered king lists or secure palaces/royal tombs identify the system.
- **"Priest-king"** is a modern label for a bearded stone figure, not proof of priestly monarchy. Female figurines **do not prove matriarchy**; inheritance rules are unknown.
- Cotton textile evidence, spindle whorls and needles support weaving; wool and other fibres occur in wider discussions. Draped garments, headdresses, jewellery and hairstyles are inferred from figurines/sculpture. Do not assume silk was a universal everyday fabric.

4. Food production and animals

- Regional farming: **wheat and barley** prominent in Punjab/Sindh; pulses including peas/horse gram, sesame, mustard, dates and melons; rice-related finds at **Lothal/Rangpur** and millets in suitable regions. Do not infer every listed crop was grown at every site or treat all “millet” as ragi.
- **Kalibangan—cross-furrowed ploughed field**; **Banawali—terracotta plough model**. Wooden plough use is inferred; iron ploughshares are not characteristic Harappan technology.
- Indus flood-recession farming: sow after floods, harvest before the next inundation; winter wheat/barley roughly November–April. Rainfall, local wells and other arrangements also mattered; no single irrigation model fits the whole region.
- **Cotton** is a major early South Asian crop/textile association; later Greek *sindon* is linked with Sindh. Surplus supported towns/crafts, but buildings labelled **“granaries”** and tax-in-kind systems remain interpretations.
- Cattle/zebu, sheep, goats, buffalo and pigs; dogs/cats and other animals are represented. Fish, molluscs and other animal foods supplemented plant foods; dairying has archaeological support.
- Familiarity with elephants/rhinos does not automatically prove domestication. **Surkotada equid remains have a disputed horse identification**; this was **not a horse/chariot-centred civilisation**.

5. Crafts, art and pottery

Craft / object	Recall
Metallurgy	Copper, bronze, gold, silver, lead/tin in relevant contexts; **no established Harappan iron industry**. Copper objects often outnumber tin bronze; bronze label does not mean all tools were bronze.
Objects	Axes, knives, spears, needles, mirrors, rings, bangles and vessels; “no weapons” is false. The source contradicts itself on short swords, so avoid a universal claim about their absence/presence.
Bronze dancing girl	**Mohenjo-daro**; lost-wax metal casting; bangles and confident stance.
Bearded stone figure	**Mohenjo-daro**; draped patterned cloak; conventionally called priest-king, actual role unknown.
Beads and jewellery	Carnelian, jasper, agate/crystal, steatite, shell, faience and metals; gold/silver ornaments at **Allahdino**. **Chanhudaro and Lothal—bead-working centres**.
Other crafts	Shell bangles, ivory/bone working, seals, boats, brick-making, terracotta toys/carts and animal/human figurines; spinning/weaving.
Pottery	Usually wheel-made, well-fired **red ware with black painted designs**; plain ware too. **Black-on-red ≠ the distinct black-and-red ware category**.
Forms / motifs	Dish-on-stand, bowls, jars, perforated vessels; geometric lines/circles, plants/pipal, birds, fish and animals. Storage/cooking/serving functions; specific brewing interpretations need evidence.

- Harappans used silver; **“first silver users in the world” is unsupported**. Trepanation-like skull modifications reported at Kalibangan/Lothal do not prove a generally advanced surgical system.
- Terracotta is fired clay; calling all terracotta “unsophisticated” mistakes material for artistic quality. Figurines may be toys, symbols or ritual objects; function needs context.

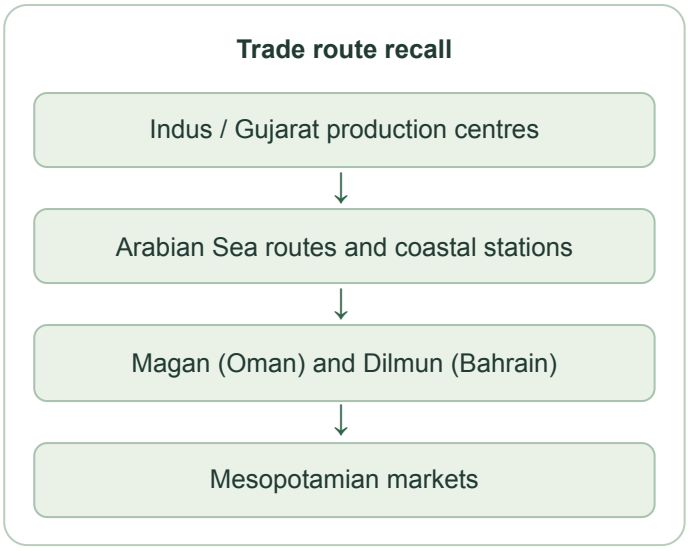
6. Seals, script and standards

- Usually **square steatite seals**, with motifs and short inscriptions; also other shapes/materials. Used in identification, sealing goods and exchange; amuletic/ritual uses possible, not all seals necessarily merchant name tags.
- **Unicorn motif** is especially common; humped bulls, elephants, rhinos and other animals occur. The unicorn is a distinct convention, not simply an identified rhinoceros. Fish-shaped **signs** should not be confused with the commonest animal pictures.
- **Undeciphered, non-alphabetic sign system**; many short inscriptions. Commonly **right-to-left**; some direction variants occur. “All writing was boustrophedon” and a fully known logosyllabic reading are not established.
- Roughly **400 signs** in common inventories; higher counts depend on treating variants separately. No secure identification of language, ruler names or the meaning of every symbol. NCERT discussion of script and authority.
- **Cubical chert weights**; lower series **1,2,4,8,16,32,64**, larger denominations in a different higher-value series. **16** is a useful conventional metrological recall, not the sole base for all arithmetic.
- **Lothal—ivory measuring scale; Mohenjo-daro—shell measuring object**; other measuring devices reported from Saurashtra. Textbook reconstructed “foot” **37.6 cm** and cubit **51.8–53.3 cm** are proposed measures, not universal standards proven at every site.

7. Trade and raw materials

- Internal exchange supplied cities with crops, livestock and craft materials; **bullock carts**, river transport and sea-going boats linked regions. No confirmed minted coin currency; exchange is conventionally described as barter, with more complex arrangements possible.
- **Meluhha**: commonly identified with the Indus region in Mesopotamian records; **Dilmun—Bahrain region; Magan—Oman region**. These are connected trade regions, not three stops all outside Harappan territory.
- Indus seals/sealings abroad and West Asian-type objects in the Indus region support contact; **Ur, Susa, Nippur, Bahrain and Failaka** are recurring associations. **Lothal**: trade/craft centre and basin interpreted by excavators as a dockyard; its precise function has been debated.
- Exchanged commodities: carnelian beads, shell/ivory, timber and other craft products; West Asian texts mention Meluhhan goods. Perishable imports such as textiles/wool, leather and perfume rarely survive; exact source assignments are not all equally secure.

Material	Source-network recall
Copper	**Khetri/Rajasthan**, Balochistan and Oman
Gold	Southern India/Kolar and northwestern networks; provenance varies
Tin	Afghanistan/Iran and wider networks—important for bronze
Lapis lazuli	**Badakhshan, Afghanistan**; **Shortughai is a trading outpost**, not the mine
Steatite	Rajasthan and other sources; Iranian links sometimes proposed
Jade / turquoise	Pamir/Central Asian and Iranian/Khorasan routes proposed; specific mineral identifications/provenance require care
Bitumen	Balochistan/West Asian networks; waterproofing association
Silver / lead	Rajasthan and other regional/West Asian sources proposed; not one exclusive mine for all finds



8. Belief, ritual and burial: evidence first

- Great Bath and features called **fire altars at Kalibangan/Lothal** suggest ritual activity. No securely identified monumental temple tradition comparable to Egypt/Mesopotamia; **absence of such temples does not prove modern secularism or absence of religion**.
- Female figurines → possible fertility/mother-goddess readings; pipal/tree and animal motifs → possible nature symbolism. Horned seated figure → conventional **"Pashupati/proto-Shiva" interpretation**, not confirmed identity or evidence that only upper classes worshipped it.
- "Pashupati" seal: elephant, tiger, rhinoceros, buffalo and small antelope/deer figures; a cross-legged seated figure. Later religious comparisons are useful hypotheses, not direct translations of an undeciphered inscription.
- Objects interpreted as linga/yoni and amulets do not establish a complete pantheon or specific belief in ghosts. NCERT on interpretation.
- **Extended/complete, fractional/secondary and urn-related burials** occur; north–south orientation is common in some cemeteries, with regional variation. Cremation/post-cremation readings require careful context; bones need not have been exposed specifically to birds/beasts.
- **Harappa—coffin burial/Cemetery H; Kalibangan—different grave types, some symbolic/empty graves; Lothal—paired burial; Ropar—reported human/dog association**. Grave goods include pots, ornaments/tools; they cannot independently establish a doctrine of afterlife or inheritance rules.

9. Site–feature atlas

Site / location	Diagnostic features and excavators
Harappa—Ravi, Punjab, Pakistan	**Daya Ram Sahni, 1921**; later M.S. Vats. Platforms/buildings traditionally called granaries, working floors, Cemetery H, coffin burial, stone torsos; **not the bronze dancing girl site**.
Mohenjo-daro—Indus, Sindh, Pakistan	**R.D. Banerji, 1922**; later Marshall, K.N. Dikshit, E.J.H. Mackay. **Great Bath, bronze dancing girl, bearded figure**, wells/drains, cotton evidence, pillared buildings. "College of priests" and "granary" are conventional labels; skeletons do not prove one invasion massacre.
Lothal—Bhogava/Sabarmati estuarine region, Gujarat	**S.R. Rao**, excavations **1955–62**; basin/dockyard interpretation, bead workshop, warehouse platforms, ivory scale, rice husk reports, boat model, seal contacts, fire-altars interpretation and paired burial. Different sectors/platforms; not a universal six-sector model for every town.

Site / location	Diagnostic features and excavators
Kalibangan—Ghaggar, Rajasthan	**Amlanand Ghosh** survey; **B.B. Lal/B.K. Thapar**, excavations from **1960**. **Ploughed field, fire-altars interpretation, fortified sectors, early+mature phases**, decorated floor bricks and varied graves; drainage differs from Mohenjo-daro. Name = **black bangles**, not merely clay bangles.
Chanhudaro—Sindh, Pakistan	**N.G. Majumdar**, then **Mackay**; bead/seal craft specialisation, toy cart models; conventionally no separate citadel. **Not confirmed human sacrifice**.
Dholavira—Khadir island, Kutch	**J.P. Joshi**, later **R.S. Bisht, 1989/90–2005**; **stone construction, multiple divisions, reservoirs, dams/channels, ten-sign inscription**, distinctive cemetery/memorial structures. Seasonal **Mansar and Manhar streams—not the Luni**.
Rakhigarhi—Hisar, Haryana	Large settlement with early/mature evidence; **Amarendra Nath**, later teams; cemetery and craft/urban evidence. Often described as India's largest Harappan site; reported area depends on mound boundaries/survey method.
Bhirrana—Fatehabad, Haryana	Early regional sequence; **L.S. Rao** excavations; incised potsherd figure compared with the dancing-girl posture. **A separate site, not another name for Rakhigarhi**.
Banawali—Haryana, ancient drainage/Rangoi region	**R.S. Bisht, 1973–74 onwards**; early/mature/later phases, barley, seals, **terracotta plough** and fire-altars interpretation.
Rangpur—Bhadar, Gujarat	M.S. Vats, later S.R. Rao; regional later Harappan pottery/rice-related evidence; not automatically an independent major seaport.
Alamgirpur—Hindon, Meerut, UP	**Y.D. Sharma, 1958**; Late Harappan pottery, beads and cloth impression; eastern extent cue.
Ropar/Rupnagar—Sutlej, Punjab, India	**Y.D. Sharma**, excavations from **1953**; multi-period sequence, cemetery and human/dog burial report.
Kot Diji—Sindh, Pakistan	**F.A. Khan, 1955 onwards**; Early Harappan fortification/settlement, fire/destruction layers; burning alone does not prove conquest.
Amri—Sindh, Pakistan	**N.G. Majumdar, 1929**; pre-/early Harappan tradition and later sequences; not a simple village-to-post-Harappan jump.
Surkotada—Kutch, Gujarat	**J.P. Joshi, 1964**; fortified settlement, cemetery, debated horse/equid identification; **not on the main Sabarmati**.
Sutkagendor—Dasht drainage, Balochistan	Aurel Stein and later work; western coastal-trade station, fortification and ceramics. Present distance from sea does not securely prove one particular uplift event.
Shortughai—Afghanistan	Northern trade outpost linked with lapis networks; beyond the usual four-point extent diagram
Daimabad—Pravara, Maharashtra	Southern Late Harappan association, later Chalcolithic phases; bronze hoard chronology/cultural attribution require care
Desalpur, Rojdi, Bhagatrav; Padri/Balakot	Gujarat regional centres and coastal/northwestern craft/trade networks; identify phase before generalising

10. Decline, continuity and comparison

- **After c.1900 BCE**: many large cities contract/are abandoned; changes in seals, writing, standard weights, crafts and long-distance trade. Population and practices continue in transformed regional settlements.

- **Multiple proposed factors**: weaker monsoons/aridity, changing river/flood regimes, local floods/tectonics, shifting trade and subsistence. Their timing and impact differ by region; **a single proven cause is not established**.
- **"Aryan invasion destroyed all cities" is an outdated blanket explanation**. Climate evidence does not date the entire urban civilisation to 8000 years ago or prove that every region declined simultaneously.
- Late zones: **Cemetery H/west Punjab; east Punjab; Jhukar/Sindh; Rangpur/Gujarat; Ganga–Yamuna doab**. Smaller settlements, diversified farming and winter/summer cropping in suitable regions; exchange/crafts persist unevenly.
- Late sites include **Prabhas Patan, Rangpur, Bet Dwarka, Manda, Sanghol, Daulatpur, Alamgirpur, Hulas, Daimabad** and regional Cholistan settlements. **PGW is a separate later/regional ceramic tradition—not the uniform replacement at every Late Harappan site**.
- Compare: Harappan standardised urban infrastructure and short undeciphered inscriptions; Mesopotamian cuneiform and Egyptian hieroglyphic records are deciphered, with clearer royal/temple institutions. **All three had their own distinctive art, pottery and planning**; "other civilisations had none" is false.

Research and heritage developments

- **Dholavira inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List, 2021**; major water-management and urban-design example. UNESCO property.
- **Union Budget 2020–21** proposed five iconic archaeological destinations with site museums: **Rakhigarhi, Dholavira, Hastinapur, Sivasagar and Adichanallur**. Proposal ≠ proof that all work is complete. Protection/museum announcements at Rakhigarhi should be read with their notification/project dates.
- **2016 Bhirrana study** proposed much earlier regional occupation and linked climate/subsistence change with de-urbanisation. Earlier occupation **does not move the mature urban phase from c.2600 BCE to 7000 BCE**; rice is not universally drought-resistant. Primary climate study.
- **2019 Rakhigarhi genome**: one successfully analysed Harappan individual, with Iranian-related and South Asian hunter-gatherer-related ancestry and no detected Steppe-pastoralist ancestry in that individual. **Not a "dominant Harappan gene", a fixed 25–30% for every South Asian, proof of a language, or proof that all Harappans resembled one modern regional group**. Primary study.

11. PYQ recall and answer plans

Prelims year	Question cue	Answer / elimination
2021	Dams, channels, connected reservoirs	**Dholavira (a)**
2019	Not a Harappan site: Chanhudaro/Kot Diji/Sohgaura/Desalpur	**Sohgaura (c)**
2013	Great palaces/temples; male+female deities; war chariots	Conventional exam answer **2 only (b)**; religious identifications remain interpretations
2011	Predominantly secular; cotton textiles	Conventional exam answer **both (c)**; "secular" here must not be treated as a modern constitutional claim
2002	Site–finding matching	**Lothal—dockyard; Kalibangan—ploughed field; Dholavira—ten-sign inscription; Banawali—plough model (b)**

Prelims year	Question cue	Answer / elimination
2002	Cow/elephant/rhino/tiger representation	**Cow (a)** in this question's conventional classification; bulls are prominently represented

- **2014 GS I**: “To what extent has the urban planning and culture of the Indus Valley Civilization provided inputs to the present day urbanization? Discuss.” Build around drainage, water storage, street/block planning and construction standards; assess modern scale, equity, ecology and the absence of proven direct institutional continuity.
- **2015 GS I**: “The ancient civilization in Indian sub-continent differed from those of Egypt, Mesopotamia and Greece in that its culture and traditions have been preserved without a breakdown to the present day. Comment.” Discuss selective continuities—crafts, cultivation, ornaments and symbolic traditions—alongside major changes, undeciphered script and the danger of assuming every resemblance proves continuity.
- **1996**: “Write about the chief features of the town planning in Indus Valley Civilization.” Organise: city divisions → streets/houses → materials → drainage → water; add Dholavira/Chanhudaro exceptions.

Practice-key corrections

- **Q9 is malformed**: its third “statement” is only “The Great Bath of Mohenjo-Daro”; the printed answer cannot repair a missing assertion.
- **Q11**: right-to-left is the usual script direction; universal boustrophedon is unsafe. **Q12**: small rooms do not prove slavery.
- **Q14**: pottery was strongly utilitarian; the statement “less utilitarian” is false, so the printed all-three key is unreliable.
- **Q15**: conventional religious readings are not sufficient proof of every listed belief. **Q23**: Kalibangan means **black bangles**, so “bangles of clay” is not the correct meaning.
- “Founders” in site questions means **modern discoverers/excavators**, not founders of ancient settlements. Horse, dockyard, granary and largest-site questions require the qualifications above.

12. One-minute recall

- **Harappa—Ravi—Sahni | Mohenjo-daro—Indus—Banerji | Lothal—Bhogava—Rao | Kalibangan—Ghaggar—plough**.
- **Dholavira—water + stone + ten signs | Chanhudaro—beads/no separate citadel | Banawali—model plough**.
- **Cotton, copper/bronze, chert weights, steatite seals; no established iron industry; script undeciphered**.
- **1900 BCE = urban transformation, not extinction of people and all culture**.